Routledge
Taylor & Francis Group

Journal of Ethnic and Migration Studies

ISSN: 1369-183X (Print) 1469-9451 (Online) Journal homepage: https://www.tandfonline.com/loi/cjms20

‘Neutrality Comes From Inside Us’: British-Asian and Indian Perspectives on Television News after 11 September

Shakuntala Banaji & Ammar Al-Ghabban

To cite this article: Shakuntala Banaji & Ammar Al-Ghabban (2006) ‘Neutrality Comes From Inside Us’: British-Asian and Indian Perspectives on Television News after 11 September, Journal of Ethnic and Migration Studies, 32:6, 1005-1026, DOI: 10.1080/13691830600761495

To link to this article: https://doi.org/10.1080/13691830600761495

Published online: 16 Aug 2006.

Submit your article to this journal

Article views: 448

View related articles

Citing articles: 4 View citing articles

Full Terms & Conditions of access and use can be found at
https://www.tandfonline.com/action/journalInformation?journalCode=cjms20

Journal of Ethnic and Migration Studies
Vol. 32, No. 6, August 2006, pp. 1005–1026

Routledge
Taylor & Francis Group

'Neutrality Comes From Inside Us': British-Asian and Indian Perspectives on Television News after 11 September

Shakuntala Banaji and Ammar Al-Ghabban

This paper focuses on responses to the viewing of television news channels during and after 11 September 2001 by a sample of Indian viewers in Bombay and British-Asian viewers in South-East England. Viewers' perceptions of neutrality, bias, reliability and vested interests within news channels and organisations are discussed, alongside the manner in which issues of gender, age and religion impact on the meanings made from and imputed to the news coverage of the attacks on America and Afghanistan. As well as considering the ways in which multilingual and sometimes transnational families experience television news in the contemporary arena, the paper addresses questions about the political significance and social impact of news broadcasts within communities with pre-existing beliefs and world views. We argue that the ways in which many so-called 'international' news channels covered issues of blame, evidence and retribution with regard to the Twin Tower and Pentagon attacks raised levels of tension, increased communal dislikes and reinforced pre-existing animosities against Muslim communities across the world.

Keywords: Neutrality; Religion; September 11; Television News Viewers

Introduction: Interpreting News Talk

Concluding his book *Live, Direct and Biased*: *Making Television News in the Satellite Age*, Brent McGregor (1997: 216) advises: 'It is an abdication of personal responsibility to expect the television news (or any other media source) to provide us with a complete view without any effort on our part'. Side-stepping issues of

Shakuntala Banaji is Researcher in the Centre for the Study of Children, Youth and Media at the University of London. Correspondence to: Dr S. Banaji, Centre for the Study of Children, Youth and Media, Institute of Education, University of London, 23–9 Emerald Street, London WC1N 2SQ. E-mail: s.banaji@ioe.ac.uk. Ammar Al-Ghabban is Researcher at the Open University. Correspondence to: Dr A. Al-Ghabban, 47 Marsala Rd, Lewisham, London SE13 7AA. E-mail: Versova@aol.com

ISSN 1369-183X print/ISSN 1469-9451 online/06/061005-22 © 2006 Taylor & Francis
DOI: 10.1080/13691830600761495

politics and control in relation to news construction and output, he continues, '[t]o some extent, we get the news we deserve, and whether that is just 24 hours of the "white noise of the news" . . . or something more profound depends on what active role we play in assembling our own jigsaw of truth'. Seeking to tease out the nature and extent of 'active' news viewing taking place within multilingual South-Asian[1] households, we conducted in-depth interviews between December 2001 and March 2002 with 24 viewers aged between 7 and 60 years, from Hindu, Muslim and Sikh backgrounds, in India and the UK. These interviews primarily focus on the mediated events of 11 September 2001 and the aftermath, but they are also the bases for discerning different 'jigsaws of truth' constructed by viewers.

Our sample consisted of four family groups—the Gujrals and the Akthar-Khan household in Bombay and the Sharifs and the Singh-Kaur family in South-East England—as well as a focus group of British-Bangladeshi school students in London. Qualitative methods were the obvious choice for data collection. The transcripts that form the bulk of our data were gathered through semi-structured individual, group and focus-group interviews. We needed to balance the requirements of the research project in terms of specific data on news consumption post-9/11 with the desire of interviewees to move towards discussions of politics, anecdotes and personal experience. We were also aware of the need to reduce possible hierarchical differences between ourselves as researchers and those participating in the interviews (cf. Fontana and Frey 1998). Our sample encompassed people from different class and religious backgrounds, necessitating sensitivity to issues of power and enfranchisement. Bearing in mind power relationships within families, which often cluster along gender lines, we conducted separate interviews with men and women. In addition, the diversity of age group (four aged 7–10, seven aged 14–15, one aged 17, four aged 20–30, four aged 30–40 and four aged 40–60) meant that questions had to be inclusively formulated. Responses from younger children were followed up with shorter or simpler questions as well as repetitions of their statements. Interviewees of different age groups and genders within the same household were encouraged to feel that their contributions were equally valid.

The interviews and analysis covered: (1) themes such as presentation and content of news; memories of 11 September; representations of Muslims and news bias; (2) comparative sample variables such as gender, religion, country, age; and (3) recurrent concerns around local and global politics. We developed a snapshot model of television news consumption patterns within our sample and utilised Critical Discourse Analysis (Barker and Galasinski 2002) to make sense of interviewees' statements about their experience of television news. Almost as interesting as the things that transnational and multilingual news viewers say *about news,* we suggest, are the implications of what they *choose to say* and what *not* to say about news and politics.

In all instances we were careful to ensure that interviewees understood the research we were conducting. We informed them verbally of the nature of the research, who we were carrying it out for and where it would be disseminated.

Several interviewees said things on tape but asked for the transcripts to remain confidential. We assured them that this would be the case. In the quoted extracts, all names have been altered to ensure confidentiality, and locations as well as other identificatory details have been omitted. We asked interviewees if they would like to receive copies of the transcripts of their interviews but in all cases were told that it would not be necessary. However, in two cases, interest was expressed in the outcome of the research.

The qualitative approach employed here creates a snapshot model of the complex interactions between 'global' politics, 'international' news and 'multilingual' viewers after a specific event, rather than providing any general rules and principles about the viewing of news with regard to 'critical events'. Specific views expressed by individual interviewees should not be seen as representative of the religious, class or gender groups from which they hail. Instead, the constant connecting up and reassessing of religious or political beliefs, familial and community relationships, opinions and news viewing which takes place within our sample may offer a framework for understanding the role of news viewing in other communities and amongst other groups of viewers. It may also serve as a basis for critiqueing some of the processes and trends at play in the shaping of current television news agendas and representations.

During interviews, the themes of gender, ethnicity, politics, news presentation and content did not always neatly fit into separate categories. In the talk of interviewees, topics are constructed and reconstructed as more or less important depending on the age, social background, beliefs, location and concerns of individual news viewers. Intertextual references to what Chris Barker (1999: 56) calls 'a sort of electronic bricolage', overlapping concepts, contradictions and confusions exist alongside cogent political responses and sharp critical references to specific events and details of news output. Memory, time and proximity to other political events also prove highly significant in influencing the direction taken by interviews about news viewing.

In what follows we focus on a number of issues related to gender, religion and political identity, which emerged as the most salient factors affecting interpretations of and responses to satellite news broadcasts following 11 September 2001. Drawing upon comments made by viewers in both India and the UK, we raise three interlinked questions. Firstly, assuming aspects of religion to be significant in structuring responses to the news (here, of 9/11 and the bombing of Afghanistan), how do opinions expressed by Muslim, Sikh and Hindu viewers from similar socio-economic backgrounds compare? Secondly, in what ways, if any, have religious and political anxieties and conflicts within South-Asian diasporic and Indian communities been affected by prevalent discourses about terrorism and Islam on CNN, BBC World, Star News, Sky and other satellite channels? And lastly, how do perceptions of neutrality and bias, and of the independence of news organisations, impact both on the meanings that viewers make from what they see and hear and on their habits of news consumption?

News Formats and Viewing Patterns

The style and presentation of television news on both satellite and terrestrial channels generated considerable debate even within individual families. Maninder Singh, whose wife, Gurpreet Kaur, said that she got much of her news from Hindi and Punjabi news channels, told us that his shifts at work kept him out of the house so that he felt he missed almost all of the main news programmes on BBC1. He explained that he rarely caught a whole bulletin and never managed to sit through discussions on the news because he either got called out or fell asleep. His 7-year-old son, Paramjit, was quick to point out: 'But Dad, you watch the same stories on Sky all the time that we watch on BBC'. This suggests that, firstly, for viewers with erratic work schedules, rolling news or 24-hour coverage may be the primary source of news as opposed to the terrestrial news programmes. Secondly, in line with the argument that the proliferation of news channels is ultimately 'insignificant' in that most channels simply reproduce the same narratives and ideologies (Boyd-Barrett 1997: 143; Paterson 1997: 145), Paramjit's assessment implies just how interchangeable Western news channels are seen to be by some multilingual viewers.

In the Sharif household, channel flicking was reported as an entrenched way of viewing news—as opposed to other genres of programme, which they said they watched all the way through. In the news frenzy following the 11 September attacks, the Sharifs watched CNN, BBC 24, BBC 1, Channel 4, PTV and Al-Jazeera. They channel-hopped in the hope of finding more news than they felt they were getting on each of the particular channels, becoming increasingly frustrated with CNN and the BBC for what they saw as a monolithic and repetitive attention to America. Safira and Asifa, although in agreement with the Sharifs in their assessment of content coverage, had more to say about presentation:

> *Safira*: Actually, though I did watch BBC, I found the coverage very dry, very staid. I didn't find the coverage so interesting as on CNN or Star News. I feel they must have not taken a very emotional perspective. Once I switched to them and they were doing some coverage about a hotel where terrorists was staying in London and I found it so staid and so monotonous that I had to change the channel, because actually it was only one voice that was doing it. Whereas Star News and CNN they use a lot of coverage and . . . I think they had written 'When Terror Strikes' . . . on the bottom and it was quite interesting. . . . 'So many people caught', and 'Troops gone into this region in Afghanistan', and things like 'Gone into a hotel' and 'Found this passport', which actually you may miss out if you are listening.

Safira's statements suggest that, at times, the pleasures and permutations of presentational style may outweigh other, perhaps more overtly ideological, issues in channel choice. With the exception of Safira's family, in all the households we encountered, women were less likely than men or children to control the process of news viewing. Several asserted that, but for husbands or children, they would either have listened to the radio, or have watched different channels to the ones generally on

in the household. In India, language too was seen to be a factor acting as a barrier to the consumption of certain news items. However, by dint of watching the same item at different times on news in English and Hindi or Gujarati, some women whose English was not fluent became able to match images to commentaries from other language channels.

Gendered Responses?

Women in all our family groups were inclined to dwell on their shock, anxieties and reactions to images of suffering, while men moved away from their own instantaneous feelings (especially about footage of the Twin Towers) to a discourse of active concern and/or retribution. The following exchange gives a sense of the first kind of discourse and also exemplifies a position taken up by a South-Asian viewer in relation to the news of this salient event:

> *Himani*: I watched the second plane flying into the building. I still have the image of the plane smashing into the building and pushing its way between the bricks. High speed flight, like a movie. It went right inside the building.
> *Interviewer*: How did you feel as you watched it?
> *Himani*: I felt terrible. I felt what a horrible thing is happening. It was very bad. . . . I thought there were tiny stones falling from the building. Then I realised that they were human beings. Men. At that height they seemed like stones. . . . It was an accident. A very big accident. It was horrible. It wasn't an accident actually. [*Interviewer*: Yes.] It was deliberate. That was what was so shocking.

The emphatic repetition of words like 'horrible' and 'very bad', or the confusion and clarification of 'accident' and 'deliberate', to signify this viewer's revulsion, may initially seem noteworthy. However, once this diction has been registered, other issues, such as the lack of any responses to the verbal commentary, are of equal interest.

The fading out of the significance of verbal mediation and the foregrounding of the visual mode in Himani's experience of television news of September 11 becomes all the more interesting in the context of repeated assertions by other viewers such as Umera, Yasmin, Salman and Gurpreet that, although they do not understand Arabic, they watch Al-Jazeera to catch glimpses of an alternative take on politics and the world post-9/11. In addition, the spectacular dimension of the television news experience, in the case of events such as wars and/or terrorist attacks, leads Himani (and other viewers) to make comparisons with other audiovisual genres, notably films, thus perhaps undermining claims to a higher truth status associated with television news. Fiske (1987: 281) points out that, while television news is traditionally a 'high status' genre, its truth status may be more akin to fiction genres than its producers and consumers have liked to admit. Kellner (2003a: 87) also remarks that the reporting of the World Trade Center attacks looked 'like a disaster film'. Moving between her distress and the event's visual connotations, Yasmin illustrates this blurring of the line between 'fact' and 'fiction':

> *Yasmin*: It was shocking, yes. Terribly shocking. . . . Yes! We just thought it was just like a film actually. We felt really sad, actually, we felt really sorry for the people who died in the building and in the planes. And we felt really angry for the people who did it. I did. And then when I thought about it, I thought, 'My God, this looks like one of the Americans films. . . . Like *Godzilla*'.

The implicit acknowledgement that the apparently 'real' can be simulated technologically, in comments about the filmic nature of the television coverage, is still more significant where viewers have pre-existing reasons for distrusting the testimony of one or another news channel.

Returning to the issue of gender, although both Arvind and Salman (males) report feeling 'bad' and sad' on watching the news of the attack on the Twin Towers, their responses are cast, perhaps more self-consciously, in a more concrete and active mould than those of Himani and Yasmin:

> *Interviewer*: How were you feeling?
> *Arvind*: I was feeling very bad . . . the number of people . . . the loss of life.
> *Interviewer*: Do you remember the first emotion you had when you were watching it?
> *Arvind*: Yeah. I thought that people should be literally tortured to death who masterminded all that. [pause] They should be tortured to death.

Arvind quickly thinks about violent retribution against the perpetrators, despite our initial cueing of a psychological response to the deaths on 11 September, while Salman speaks of particular cases, avoiding descriptions of wider emotion:

> *Salman*: Well, we had relatives in Queens in New York so we rang just to make sure that everything was fine. We have relatives in Boston so we rang them to make sure everything was okay. Very sadly I heard my brother-in-law knew somebody, an Arab family in Boston, their pregnant daughter was on one of the planes, so yeah, it was pretty sad.

Salman was not the only interviewee to refer to concern for relatives abroad and to invoke a sense of transnational family networks. Safira and Nadeem in Bombay spoke of relatives and friends both in Pakistan and in America with whom their families communicated directly following September 11. Clearly, as comments by women viewers show, such practical anxieties were not the only ones at play in South-Asian and/or diasporic families. However, the individual choice to dwell, or to refuse to dwell, on initial images of the towers falling may represent a kind of resistance to perceived attempts by the televisual media to sweep all viewers into a frenzy of horror, grief and revenge (Kellner 2003a). The violent excess of Arvind's wish that those responsible for the attacks 'should literally be tortured to death' reflects not only his immediate response, but also his certainty, informed by both subsequent commentaries and his prior beliefs, that the hijackers and their sponsors were Muslims.

Images: Selection, Memory, Authenticity

Virtually all interviewees referred to images of the planes crashing into the buildings and of people's panic as the most memorable. Several found it difficult to recall other images that had left a lasting impression on them. Rihana reminded us of the 'pictures of the Palestinian crowds cheering' upon hearing about what had happened in America; she explained that she felt that CNN was using these images, which she believed to be associated with events in 1992, to misrepresent the Palestinians. Other images vividly recollected were the chaos of the debris at Ground Zero; the faces of horrified people; clips of relatives as they broke down listening to cell-phone messages from their loved ones; and, repeatedly, the faces of Tony Blair, George Bush and Osama bin Laden. The former two leaders were seen to be attempting to rally their respective nations for particular causes. Blair's expression of sincerity and concern was mentioned several times with distaste. Gurpreet and Yasmin saw him as involving residents of Britain needlessly in the problems of the United States. Suresh was sarcastic about the way in which channels like BBC World and Star News showed Blair rushing from country to country and commented that Fox News made 'George Bush out to be some kind of superhero . . . like Mel Gibson saving the world'. Seven-year-old Fayez clearly remembered Bush's 'yellow hair' and 7-year-old Paramjit was fascinated by images of Osama bin Laden with his 'turban, beard and gun'.

Commenting on the power of such images and the meanings people make from them, Nadeem mentioned the racist killing of a Sikh wearing a turban in America. She maintained that because the television news 'wants to show the Taliban as evil', all bearded and turbaned men suddenly began to look dangerous and suspect. The normative and suggestive authority of images deployed after the initial pictures of the attacks was clearly a grave concern for South-Asian Muslim interviewees. Likewise, the question of the reliability of images used by satellite news channels was raised on several occasions, most forcefully during the focus-group discussion:

> *Shabana*: You know that video of bin Laden talking, they had no date or nothing.
> *Interviewer*: There was more than one bin Laden tape, wasn't there?
> *Shabana*: Yeah none of them had dates on. Normally they have dates on but none of these had dates. On one of the Sky documentaries channels they're saying that one of the tapes is similar to the other one of his speeches—the background and everything is same, just he's saying different things.
> *Interviewer*: So what do you think about the bin Laden tapes?
> *Shabana*: They're old . . . they're from other cases and stuff.
> *Interviewer*: Do you remember the tape where he's talking about the buildings collapsing? . . . What did you think about that tape?
> *Shahidul*: That's not true.
> *Interviewer*: What do you mean?
> *Shahidul*: It's like it's a fake.
> *Shofique*: The news is against Islam.
> *Interviewer*: You're saying, Shahidul, that it's a fake—why?
> *Shahidul*: His face looks different.

> *Interviewer*: So his face looks different from the other tapes?
> *Shahidul*: Yeah.
> *Interviewer*: So do you think the other tapes are real but that one isn't?
> *Shahidul*: Yeah . . . America has got the latest technology that comes out so they can make anything they want, so how are we supposed to believe in it?

This exchange illustrates the way in which ideas and viewpoints premised on pre-existing beliefs may be developed and fixed, rather than challenged, within the context of group discussion. All of the voices present not only actively distrust much that they experience on Western news channels, they also marshal specific evidence to substantiate their beliefs.

In the case of the bin Laden tapes, the media also contribute to speculation about authenticity: Shabana speaks of a Sky documentary on this very issue. At one level, the extent to which these London teenagers focus on the detail of the tapes—bin Laden's face, the background in the video and the dates on the tapes—reflects a high degree of media literacy and confidence in their own cognisance of media (mis)representations of people. They also display a deeply-held belief in the power of institutions or governments to call upon cutting-edge technology to manipulate and misinform news viewers. At another level, the sense of certainty displayed by these young viewers is no doubt at least partly due to their prior belief in the existence of a virulently anti-Muslim agenda in the Western media. Shofique's comment, apropos the bin Laden tapes, that 'the news is against Islam', is anything but throwaway.

Other News Sources: Humour and Interactivity

In tandem with distrust of the authenticity and motivations of television news, we found a desire to access other news sources. In general, newspapers, radio and the internet are perceived by at least one member of each family as a useful source of alternative information to television news. Supporting the view that the net provides 'an interactive sphere where netizens can discover novel opinions and facts and themselves participate in the great dialogue of the contemporary moment' (Kellner 2003b: ix), it is seen to provide access to foreign papers and journals as well as to more 'subversive' perspectives. Suresh Gujral, Safira and Nadeem Khan in Bombay and the Sharif family in the UK all have e-mail contact with friends and relatives and receive news circulating on the Internet. In Britain, the South-Asian vernacular press such as the Punjabi *Desh-Pardes* and radio channels such as Sunrise and Radio Asia are also cited as important news sources for older female members of households, while Suresh and Salman value the international news coverage available on-line:

> *Salman*: I thought that the television news was not representative of what was really happening. And I saw double standards being applied by the news media. There wasn't full coverage or proper coverage given of, for example, the civilian deaths in Afghanistan and certainly that changed my attitude and so I virtually stopped watching television news. My sources are the internet. I will go to—for example

> this morning, I spent a long time going through the Israeli *Jerusalem Post*. I've read the news reports there about what has been happening [*Interviewer*: In Palestine?] That's right. I've written to the editors there and digested some information. I've also gone to the Pakistani news channel (PTV) and I've read the *New York Times* online edition—you know, the big headlines.

Clearly, when one member of a household accesses the internet, reads a newspaper on- or off-line and/or listens to debates on the radio, the meanings they make from this news consumption have consequences for the television news consumption of others in the family circle. We observed in the case of the Gujral family that the children, and sometimes Himani, call upon Arvind as an 'expert' commentator during news programmes. The pace of news in languages such as English, and sometimes the political and social background to issues being examined, can act as barriers to the comprehension of some members in multilingual viewing households. This catalyses the introduction of a member of the household as the opinion-giver and interpreter during news programmes. Thus Salman's wider news consumption—*The Jerusalem Post*, *The New York Times* and a Pakistani news channel, for instance—can be seen as contributing to the understandings that his family will have of the political situation post-September 11.

In this context, irreverent and satirical humour also plays a significant role in attracting younger members of families towards magazines and the internet as opposed to television news. Laughing, Rihana referred to the depiction, on the cover of *The Economist*, of a German magazine front cover displaying George Bush in baggy green combat fatigues; her sister, Hamida, explained that they had received over the internet cartoons depicting a funny amalgamation of Bush and bin Laden. Finally, emphasising that this humour was not dismissed but was regarded as legitimate critique, Rihana commented, 'I don't think that kind of questioning ever happened on the television news'. In this manner, contrastive news analyses may take place between news channels on television but also occur frequently across media and genre.

Disproportionate Coverage?

Boyd-Barrett (1997: 143) argues that 'news agencies contribute to the homogenization of global culture in form and source, while greatly multiplying the texts available within these standardized discourses'. Apparently confirming this assessment, a recurring theme throughout interviews in India and Britain was the extent to which the attack on the Twin Towers dominated the news on every channel to the exclusion of other world news. Responding to an earlier question about emotions experienced on watching footage of the Twin Towers crumbling and people falling from the buildings, Rihana explained her feelings:

> I think that the reason that I didn't cry yeah, or get overly upset, about the US affair, was that I think you've got to have a bit of perspective. Like the number of people that die in comparison in some of the areas of the world is just so, like, it's

> been happening in the world all of the time, that like aren't being shown on the news all the time, for example what's happening in Chechnya and Bosnia, in like African countries, in like [pause] you know even in Pakistan and India, you know and there people die every day. In like single incidents as well. It's just not shown. So I don't think it [the Twin Towers] was horrific enough.

Rihana's attitude to television news is an excellent example of how viewers' comparative perspectives on news may lead to a relativising of political events. Perhaps equally significantly, her cogent rationale for her lack of feeling *vis-à-vis* images of September 11, like Arvind's rationalising of his anger, may be viewed as the result of news and events both long before and after the attack.

Other viewers, too, illustrate the relativising of news events. Salman suggests that he would not have explored such questions publicly in Britain, but within his family the blanket news coverage of September 11 began to raise political questions:

> I think that news report [of America and September 11] was at the expense of everything else. We had a genocide of a million in Rwanda not so long ago and . . . so . . . after the initial shock and sympathy . . . one begins to ask these questions, you know, wait a minute, this is disproportionate.

Several others expressed frustration with the way in which 'Western' events were shown on the news as more tragic and significant than troubles in non-Western nations. For Nadeem, Qasim, Safira, Suresh, Himani and Gurpreet, events such as the Gujarat earthquake and the conflict between India and Pakistan over Kashmir deserve television coverage because of their importance to the lives of millions of viewers. Viewing several channels over a period of time, they express dissatisfaction with Western channels' 'Euro-centric' or 'American-centric' news perspectives (which are widely acknowledged, e.g. Boyd-Barrett 1997: 143; Paterson 1997: 154). However, the viewing of multiple news channels over a long period of time need not create comparative, critical or relative perspectives. A few thought that the sustained and extensive coverage of 11 September by all Western news stations was justified by the uniqueness of the event. In stark contrast to many of the other South Asians interviewed, Arvind called the television coverage of the Twin Towers attack 'the news of my life', saying that it was more momentous 'than Hiroshima and Nagasaki', indeed 'something worse than war'.

Perceptions of Content: Women's Concerns?

We did not set out to test the view that 'news in all its various forms has historically underrepresented and misrepresented women' (Byerly 1997: 248). Nonetheless, we found that South-Asian women viewers were dissatisfied with satellite news coverage post-September 11 as much because they had unanswered questions about the fate of women as because of their political or religious affiliations. Having seen Al-Jazeera footage shot in Afghanistan after the Americans started their bombing campaign, Safira had thought more about 'what the war was doing to women', explaining: 'I

don't know how [pregnant women] are going to get medical aid. Like I realised I had medicines which I was having every day so my child could grow well. I was feeling, What about these women?' Safira also called both the attacks on the Twin Towers, and those by America on Afghanistan, 'a very male thing'. She said that she felt as if George Bush 'used CNN' to 'threaten' Osama bin Laden, while Osama bin Laden 'used Al-Jazeera' to 'threaten' George Bush. Reminiscent of Fiske's (1987: 308) injunction that one should view television news as a 'masculine soap-opera', this goes further than his analysis by naming news channels as tools of powerful politicians in real material conflicts. Himani was reluctant to assert authoritative positions on television news commentaries, but told us:

> I have not heard any of the women's views on the news. There must be women involved in things but we only see the men. I want to know what they haven't shown us in Afghanistan and in America. What do the women say?

None of the men commented on the presence of children as pawns within the conflict or as recipients of the news but, for female news viewers, images of 'little' children holding guns and their own children's responses and comments on images and ideas were recurring themes. Asked whether she had continuing concerns about the 'issue of terrorism', Gurpreet explained:

> [W]hatever happens in America and whatever the Americans do, I and my children have to travel back to India again and again. . . . Now we will be on a plane to go but it is such a worrying and terrible thought that what might happen. Do you understand? And my little boy he said to me, 'Mummy, will it be bin Laden who is the pilot of our plane?' [*Interviewer*: Oh no!] . . . and all my friends . . . say that their children are now asking this same question before they get on a plane, that, 'Mummy, will bin Laden get onto the plane? Will we crash into a building?'

For British-Asians to have direct contact with family members on the subcontinent means flying. Given the way in which planes figure in television news iconography surrounding 11 September, this is clearly a matter of concern for some South-Asian mothers. Their children's preoccupation with the possibility of hijacking reinforces their own fears. Some of the images replayed on 24-hour rolling news channels at the time of the attacks on the Twin Towers were fixed, at least for some months, in people's minds.

News Agendas, Bias and Trust

News may still be presented as if it is 'objective' and 'impartial', but there appears to be widespread academic agreement about the 'social construction' of news and the 'shaping of reality' (Boyd-Barrett 1997; Fiske 1987; McGregor 1997; Paterson 1997), and that the media are 'political actors in their own right' (Curran and Seaton 2000: 1). Analysing American television news following 11 September, Kellner (2003a: 95) scathingly describes how 'broadcast television allowed dangerous and arguably deranged zealots to vent and circulate the most aggressive, fanatic, and downright

lunatic views, creating a consensus around the need for immediate military action and all-out war'. Both the choice of what becomes 'news', and the kind of emphasis given, are acknowledged to have political antecedents and consequences. In line with such analyses, almost all our interviewees told us that they felt that, on a range of channels, the selection of stories and the setting of the agenda were neither impartial nor representative of the events occurring in the world. Gurpreet, a British-Sikh, described the strong emotions that television news post-September 11 stirs in her:

> *Gurpreet*: I feel it in my bones if I watch it too much like the things that have happened in America made me think that what have they done for the rest of the world over the years? Do they take notice ever of the pain of others? [*Interviewer*: The Americans?] The Americans. The News. Like last week there was this thing happening in Gujarat. [*Interviewer*: Yes.] These terrible men are burning the homes of Muslims and burning the children alive in their beds. Now it is *Hindus* doing it. Will they show everything on the news? I don't think so.

Gurpreet is articulating her anxiety that the lack of publicity given by major news channels to cruelties perpetrated by non-Muslims in other parts of the world might be an example not just of the disdain with which America treats the troubles of any non-Americans, but also of the cynical way in which news is selected for coverage based on the power and interests of the groups being reported about. Her reference to the ethnic cleansing against Muslims by Hindus in Gujarat, which took place with the collusion of the BJP-led Government of Gujarat (Anand and Setalwad 2002; Narula 2002; Sarkar 2002), positions her as a knowledgeable and well-informed consumer of news from the subcontinent—but one with an acute sense of her own powerlessness to change the news agendas in the West. We asked if she ever wrote to complain about the news or phoned up to express her opinions. She told us that her lack of literacy in English held back her desire to make her opinions heard.

In another instance, a British-Bangladeshi student pointed out that the Western news media abandoned a principle of democracy in their pursuit of the American news agenda:

> *Imran*: There's this thing they say, 'Innocent until proven guilty'. We haven't seen nothing about why they suspect bin Laden. We haven't seen no proof.

Fiske argues that 'reading the news cynically or angrily can deconstruct its conventions and demystify their attempted ideological practice' (1987: 285). Read as such a deconstruction, Imran's critique merges 'State' and 'Media' in the phrase 'there's this thing *they* say' and separates these powerful entities out from himself and his community as well as news viewers in the repeated use of 'We'. In Imran's view, the burden of proof lies with the news media and the governments accusing bin Laden of committing a heinous crime, and has clearly been shrugged off with little regard for justice. As Imran points out, suspicion is not proof. But who's listening? Within our sample we discovered a need to know more from the news, together with frustration and anger at what was perceived to be one-sided, cynical and

untrustworthy reporting of particular stories, and the refusal to report other stories or even to consider them worthy of discussion.The extent to which people 'trusted' the news brought to them by the various channels they watched varied. Some felt that certain channels were less 'neutral', and hence less trustworthy, than others. Members of the Gujral family displayed a significant degree of anti-Muslim sentiment, while members of the Akthar-Khan family were concerned with the negative representation of Muslims by the media. But people in both families shared the view that channels such as the BBC and CNN represented 'Western interests' and hence could not be regarded as being 'neutral':

> *Nadeem*: I would say they are biased in many ways. I have that opinion though I may be wrong. With respect to Western interests and stuff like that.

Nadeem believes that the aforementioned channels tend to focus on stories relevant to specific Western audiences at the expense of issues that would interest other countries, such as the 'Kandahar hijacking' to which, in his opinion, they did not give enough coverage.[2] Their selection and prioritisation of news items clearly reflect, in his opinion, the fact that news organisations which purport to be 'global' channels are in fact grounded in the values and interests of their countries of origin.

Arvind also identifies a story that he believes was not explored as much as it should have been. He suggests that this was not because the item was not directly related to Western interests, as with the Kandahar hijacking, but because further investigation would have exposed facts that the American government would rather were left undisclosed:

> *Arvind*: After September 11 there were other incidents—one more crash at JFK, which happened in mysterious circumstances.
> *Interviewer*: How have the media dealt with that?
> *Arvind*: Media could not reach the facts and what they heard from the administration they had to abide or follow that only.

Arvind suggests that the news channels had to accept the information put out by the American government on this incident, and that to challenge that or suggest alternative explanations would have amounted to challenging the US administration. In Arvind's view, this was something that CNN chose not to do.

The relationship between news organisations and dominant political interests (Barker 1999; Kellner 2003a; Paterson 1997) was also cited by interviewees in the UK as being an explanation for the perspective(s) adopted towards political events on a global scale:

> *Salman*: The BBC is owned by the government. They say their editorials are independent but there is also an understanding to make sure, you know, what is reported and what is not.

The 'understanding' that Salman refers to between the BBC and the British government is reminiscent of Arvind's claim regarding CNN that, if pressed by 'their own government', they fall into line.

> *Safira*: I don't think the opinions were balanced at all. . . . CNN were more like one-sided. They were very sure Osama bin Laden had done it. So they just kept showing it . . . I remember reading another opinion in the newspaper . . . [CNN] were very evasive about whether [America] were going to attack Afghanistan or not so nobody knew about it and then one fine day CNN just said that so many missiles and army have gone to some unknown destination and then the next you hear is that they are bombing. . . . [pause] The coverage was very good on CNN and Star News but I felt like it was more fair when the *Times of India* came up with coverage of what America is doing. . . . In the beginning I just felt watching TV news coverage that they [the men who hijacked the planes] were sympathising with the cause of Islam and that's why they were doing it. But then when you really started *reading* you also started forming an opinion that 'No, maybe what CNN and Star are saying is not right'. I think maybe also for me it was because I started perceiving that the Americans are doing a lot of human rights violations [in Afghanistan].

In this segment of talk, a complex process of explanation takes place, evidently the articulation of months of news watching, reading and analysis. Safira suggests clearly that, in her understanding, CNN acts as a mediator for the American state, sharing its secrets, prejudices and biases: 'very evasive', 'very sure Osama bin Laden had done it', 'unknown destination'. CNN censors the views of other, perhaps more critical, sources that she begins to discover via the *Times of India* newspaper. She acknowledges that her initial view of the perpetrators of the 11 September attacks was led by the news, particularly on Star News and CNN. This is revealing because it suggests that her worldview, unlike, for instance, that of the young British-Bangladeshi students we interviewed, did not predispose her to dismiss out-of-hand the assertions made on CNN about the men who flew planes into buildings. However, as she says, when she '*really* started reading', when she paid attention to detail and examined news from other sources, the explanatory framework of CNN and Star, however stylistically 'good', seemed less reliable, less 'fair' than, for instance, those of some Indian newspapers. Safira finally ties her disillusionment with the perspective of CNN to her perception that America, the state for which CNN speaks, is actually engaged in a lot of 'human rights violations'.

Safira can discern some of the evasions and elisions of CNN in the representations on Star News, which she usually likes; this suggests her own attempts at impartiality. Other viewers had even less respect for what they see as American methods of political coercion:

> *Shofique*: There's propaganda going on [pause] showing people are suffering and everything so that they get more people into the war to help America so that they are not standing alone.
> *Interviewer*: Which channels are putting forward this view?

> *Shabana*: The CNN reporters that do the news show they are more direct, they don't say 'The President of America thinks . . . ', they're saying 'The Taliban planned it', 'They did it' and everything. . . . BBC 24 are more like 'Bush now thinks' [pause] —They're not certain, not for sure.

Thus, during interviews about news after 11 September, discussions of politics on the news often segued seamlessly into discussions of politics per se, especially where some interviewees' dissatisfaction with the perspectives offered on Western news channels pushed them to redress such perceived imbalances.

'Evidence' and 'World Views'

In a pertinent analysis of the Manichean discourse invoked to 'other' entire communities post-September 11, Kellner (2003a: 92) reminds us that Bush's dualism, mirrored by the American media, 'replicates as well the Friend/Enemy opposition of Carl Schmidt upon which Nazi politics were based'. Thus, in the aftermath of September 11, television and other news reporting complemented and/or reinforced pre-existing prejudices about specific ethnic groups. Elements within different communities viewed 'others' with enhanced suspicion and political distrust, feeding into discourses of blame and retribution.

> *Shabana*: BBC News 24 already had someone in America at that time and that person was reporting . . . and this after 11 September, the person that was there said the Canadian intelligence, they were looking into it and . . . d'you know at the Pentagon there's, I don't know how many but, there's quite a lot of Jews and that day it happened there was no Jews there.
> *Interviewer*: Where did you hear about that?
> *Shabana*: That was on BBC News 24 . . . that's when the President was saying he was gonna track down Osama bin Laden and he's gonna kill him . . . and threatening him . . . and the President knew about that Canadian intelligence were looking into . . . that there was a possibility that it could've been the Jews but Bush never done nothing about it. He just wanted Osama bin Laden dead.

The vocabulary of this 15-year-old British-Asian—'he's gonna kill him', 'threatening him'—echoed that of the President of the United States, broadcast across the world by the BBC, CNN and other networks. It displays the crude terms within which the conflict was set out by the powers that be and, unquestioned by the supposed mediators, reached screens of viewers across the globe: George Bush is going to 'get' Osama bin Laden. But nestling in Shabana's speech, alongside her anger at Bush and his threats, is a simmering anti-Semitism that should not be ignored. Islamic groups were the American government's first target in terms of post-9/11 broadcasting, but the explanations and conspiracy theories circulating informally and on the internet in subsequent days, such as the one Shabana mentions, frequently made reference to Jews. Shabana criticises the insidious manner in which broadcasting after September 11 promoted theories about the 'clash of civilisations', fundamental difference between East and West, and the 'barbarity' of Islam. This does nothing to alter her

own prejudices. Stereotypes of 'other' groups circulate in news viewing communities in part independently of media messages.

Much television news coverage of events in America and Afghanistan following 9/11 seems to have been used by viewers (even, on occasion, vividly remembered by them) in the context of pre-existing, complex discursive frames to which many very strongly subscribed. These frameworks or 'worldviews' are based on past experiences (including experiences of television news), discussions with peers, friends and relatives, religious and/or philosophical and/or political beliefs and knowledge, and well-thought-out or spur-of-the-moment analyses.

Viewing the same news bulletins on CNN and BBC World in the days leading up to and following the start of the bombing of Afghanistan, different viewers declared that the American action was a commendable and proportionate response to September 11, or was lacking in moral integrity and practical efficacy. The Akthar-Khan household in Bombay was keen to be viewed as both patriotic Indians and as moderate Muslims, in a highly volatile climate where attacks on Muslims might be justified by any apparent infringement of patriotism or even need no justification at all. They saw the bombing of Afghanistan as both politically valid and morally unjustified. Within the discourse of 'fighting terrorism', to which these viewers feel they too as Indians can be party, they express support for the attacks on Afghanistan as mediated by television news. But in discourses of 'human rights' and 'political interests', they are unequivocally critical of these violent incursions into a poor Third-World country.

'The process of othering entire communities in the communal scenario in India today cannot be separated from the stereotypes by which communities have been demeaned and internalised in everyday life. . . . Communalism is not exclusively a political phenomenon engineered by political parties and fundamentalist organisations; it is also culturally determined by the more seemingly non-political interventions of school, the neighbourhood and the family' (Bharucha 2001: 142). To Suresh, Himani, Dilip and Aditi, by their own admission, and to Arvind by his family's testimony, television news commentaries following 11 September were used to confirm the family's abiding distrust of Islam and their prejudices against Muslims:

> *Himani*: I think that Muslims are mostly all the same. This [11 September attack] was their work. The News proved that to me.
> *Suresh*: Yes, that's the thing. An inner voice tells us that somewhere or the other all the Muslims are supportive of this [attack]. Whether they come out in protest or not.
> *Interviewer*: But you also seemed to be joking about the attack. Your brother said they should hit the White House!
> *Suresh*: That's different. That was not for their cause. That's to show the Americans that unless and until you feel something yourself you won't feel for your neighbours. I don't like the Americans perspective of doing things and I don't like Muslims also.
> *Aditi*: I don't like Muslims.
> *Interviewer*: Why?

> *Aditi*: Mummy–Daddy don't like Muslims. My friends also don't like Muslims. Most of them are Hindus.

Crucially, Arvind gave no indication of such sentiments during his interview. He carefully supported and justified his ideas and kept them within what he considered to be the accepted bounds of political correctness. Nevertheless, moments of heightened negative emotion, such as his statements about wishing to have the perpetrators 'tortured to death', could be deemed, with hindsight, to connect to the worldview summed up by his daughter in the candid assertion, 'Mummy-Daddy don't like Muslims'.

Intersections of Politics, Class and Religion

Several viewers were also acutely aware of the impact on the lives of Muslims around the world of the extensive media coverage of the religion of the supposed perpetrators. They were aware that the identification of Muslims with terrorists and the categorisation of Muslims as dangerous 'others' who threaten American security and/or civilised values may well have negative consequences for other groups, as religion is not always easily discernible.

> *Interviewer*: After you watched the news about who had done it, did you feel that British Muslims would be affected?
> *Yasmin*: Yeah, we heard like stories like an Asian woman was beaten up with a baseball bat . . . .
> *Rihana*: And a Sikh taxi driver got killed I think.
> *Hamida*: And did you hear about that thing where an Asian couple was flying to New York and they got pulled off the flight?

Yasmin and her daughters name incidents ranging from murder and violence to state harassment. They are concerned with the repercussions of news not only for Muslims but also for other groups whose garb and/or skin colour might identify them visually in racist minds with the people accused on television of being terrorists. Salman, meanwhile, though cognisant of efforts by sections of the media to redress the balance, is convinced that the labelling and stereotyping of Muslims in the rest of the media will have far-reaching negative consequences for diverse sections of the community.

> *Interviewer*: What do you feel about the way that Muslims are being portrayed or represented by the media, by the BBC and CNN?
> *Salman*: If you look at the whole, I think very negatively. There have been programmes to redress the balance and of course I must give them credit for that. There was a programme on BBC2, a series where they did try to do that. I think this is where the danger is, by conducting the interviews which the BBC for Today Programme did. Because that saw them stereotyping. It's like saying every white person with a cross on his car is a racist member of the BNP so I think the danger is all the Muslims are going to be put in one basket and labelled—that is my worry.

Kellner (2003a): 89) argues that the 'images and discourses of the US television networks framed the terrorist attacks to whip up war hysteria . . . established a binary dualism between Islamic terrorism and civilization, and largely circulated war fever and retaliatory feelings'. His assessment as well as Salman's concerns about the potential effects of the stereotypical and often racist media representation of Muslims are not unfounded, as we may surmise from the following exchange:

> *Interviewer*: So, after the events of 11 September and watching it all on TV, have your views about any group or community changed at all?
> *Suresh*: Not much but I get more violent. Towards the Muslim people. I feel that my hatred has increased. . . . Most of the things in the world, the wars and riots and revolutions, there has been a trace of Islam behind that. . . . It is all of the Muslims mostly, who supported [11 September attacks]. The thinking on the news is correct. If you look you will see that they show 60 per cent of the people in Pakistan on the news were supporting Osama.

Interestingly, in Salman's earlier comments, set within a British context—'The Today programme', 'the BNP'—he is concerned about the general perception of Muslims by the non-Muslim majority. Like Kellner's analysis of the whipping up of 'war hysteria' in the USA, this is entirely applicable to other situations and contexts across the globe—such as parts of India. The very confidence with which Suresh asserts that his 'violence' and 'hatred' towards Muslims have increased after watching television news post-September 11, may indicate his belief in the universality of the views he holds. Even at a microcosmic level, Suresh feels no discomfort in speaking as he does to an interviewer 'from London'. At a macrocosmic level, what convinces him of the rightness of his own views is the expression of what are, to him, similar views, and equally importantly 'evidence', on television news channels.

This predisposition to a particular belief about Muslims in general can be viewed as a throwback to the communal hostility following partition between India and Pakistan. This explanation, however, seems to us too simplistic and implausible. A more complex sense of what might lie behind the penchant of some Hindu or Sikh viewers in India or Britain to regard as unproblematic the anti-Muslim sentiments of politicians, and the subtly derogatory portrayal of Islam by certain news channels, can be gleaned from studies of the rise of the Hindu Right (Hansen 1999; Hensman 1995; Sarkar 1993). Discussions of the burgeoning right-wing Hindu fascist culture in India and the diaspora (Bharucha 1998; Mankekar 2000; Rajagopal 2001) provide an interesting background to the views expressed here by some interviewees.

In general, viewers received and made sense of the satellite news broadcasts we discussed with them in the context of pre-existing political, religious or moral frameworks and worldviews. Yet it would be absurd to attempt to measure some abstract notion of the effect of each broadcast on the worldviews of South-Asian viewers. Rather, we maintain that, generally, those viewers who were more closely implicated, by reason of experience or group identity, with one of the groups represented by satellite channels after 11 September, were quickest to form and

express opinions counter to one of the other groups. The Hindu viewers, while most sympathetic to America and Americans in their perceived fight against 'Islamic terrorists', were also sharply critical of America when they sensed that Indian political interests were not at the forefront of American foreign policy.

Most viewers from all three communities were keen to stress that their initial responses to the visual images of the attacks in America on 11 September 2001 were ones of shock, surprise, compassion and/or dread. But some of the Hindu viewers interviewed in India also expressed the immediate fury they felt against the 'terrorists'. With hindsight, these Hindu viewers represent themselves as having 'known' that the perpetrators of the attack were 'Muslim'. The 'evidence' of news broadcasts on Star News, itself taken from Fox News and CNN, about the Koran, flight manuals, Arabic connections and Afghanistan, served to justify righteous anger against Muslims worldwide and support for the bombing of Afghanistan, which was on-going at the time of the interviews. Meanwhile Muslim viewers in India, cognisant of the political context of right-wing Hindu nationalism within which they exist, were understandably cautious about expressing their criticisms of the news. However, they did express the fear that the types of broadcast they had been watching on CNN might instigate further violence against Muslims in India and the diaspora. They also questioned statements made on CNN, Star News and BBC World about American motives for bombing Afghanistan.

In Britain, Sikh viewers were divided in their support for American actions and their portrayal in Western television news. Their more complex response to the notion and representation of 'terror' and 'terrorism' than that of the Hindu viewers in Bombay was due in large part to their own political history in the subcontinent and their experiences in the 1980s. Thus they were never wholly in agreement with the broadcasts on Sky and CNN, viewing these as connected to the power of 'corrupt' and 'cynical' politicians and governments such as those of Blair, Bush, the Taliban and Osama bin Laden. They complained that satellite news did not give them enough news about India and Pakistan, the conflict over Kashmir, the ways in which this conflict might affect the subcontinent, and what the right-wing Hindu nationalist government was doing in Gujarat.

The South-Asian Muslims interviewed in Britain were far more confident and specific in their critiques of satellite news following 11 September and did not spare channels such as PTV from these critiques. They felt that the images representing Palestinians following the attacks were misleading, while the commentaries on almost every channel were biased, stereotyped, lacking in evidence and cynically or slavishly following the dictates of the American state. Most expressed sympathy for those killed in the attacks on America and anger at the perpetrators, but none were satisfied with the reporting of the American attacks on Afghanistan, the 'evidence' against Al-Qaeda, the broadcasts about bin Laden or the representation of Muslims worldwide.

The perception of a divergence between 'reality' and news broadcasts about 11 September, the terrorists and the bombing of Afghanistan varied widely. The Muslim viewers in Britain had perceived such a divergence within hours of the attacks, while

the Muslim viewers in India and the Sikh viewers in the UK took a few weeks. The Hindu viewers took a few months, apparently questioning the news only when India was 'urged to be restrained' in its attitude to Pakistani terrorist infiltrators, while America continued to bomb Afghanistan. Religious identity was clearly the primary factor affecting viewers' credulity and faith in the accuracy of evidence about and representation of events after the terrorist attacks in America. A range of South-Asian Muslim viewers, from diverse social and educational backgrounds, felt similarly angered and misrepresented by television news. The sense that images and discussions of the attacks on America obsessed Western satellite news channels to the exclusion of other horrifying and significant world events past and present, including the aftermath of the bombing in Afghanistan, was expressed by almost all viewers in our sample. Only two Hindu viewers in India and one Sikh viewer in the UK dissented. In our later interviews in the UK, and on our return to India during the summer of 2002, viewers were discussing two main issues: the possibility of nuclear conflict between India and Pakistan, and the recent state-sponsored genocide of 3,000 Muslims in Gujarat, and ensuing political disruption. Political opinions on these issues varied, but not the sense that these were as momentous for South-Asians as September 11 was for Americans.

How were religious and political anxieties and conflicts within South-Asian diasporic and Indian communities affected by television news coverage? Our impression when in India was that the prevalence of anti-Muslim discourses amongst many middle-class Hindus was greater than ever and was often rationalised with reference to British and American satellite news broadcasts about 'Islam' and 'terrorism'. 'Even the Americans say that most Muslims are terrorists and that all terrorism springs from Islam, so why shouldn't we purge/get rid of these Muslims in India?' This was an attitude we encountered during interviews in India. The shocking silence about or smug condoning of the rape, torture and murder of Muslims in Gujarat is, we feel, not a direct consequence of the broadcasting of American views about Islam post-11 September, but is in part connected to the climate created by such broadcasts. South-Asian children in Britain described incidents of racial teasing and taunting taking place at school or college. The adults referred to the murder of a Sikh man in the USA and police harassment of Muslims on flights and around cities. The poorer Muslim youth interviewed were convinced that news channels such as BBC News 24, Sky and CNN contribute to a worldwide hatred of Muslims and a discrediting of Islam in general. Many had absolutely no faith in the willingness of these channels to give voice to any opinions but those of the British and American establishment.

For some South-Asian viewers, Western news channels—and some Asian ones too—are interchangeable and frequently indistinguishable from each other. But at an aesthetic level, many multilingual viewers revealed that they do not simply watch the news for the political content. They are interested in, intrigued by and sometimes drawn to particular presentational features of channels, such as the banners and headlines or the use of captions and text alongside oral commentary. Quite apart

from visual features of news channels, these viewers were acutely aware of what may be called the 'tone' or 'ethos' of particular channels. Although many viewers had relatively fixed, often partisan views about politics, this did not seem to lead to over-dependence on any particular news source espousing views close to their own worldview. Viewers between 15 and 30 in our sample, and some older viewers too, seem to treat satellite news channels in the manner of a 'news supermarket'. They may retain some 'brand loyalty' to channels that they happen to like for presentational reasons—colours, layout, use of images, clarity of message, language or anchor people—by watching them at least once a day, but many viewers simply shop around for new news products. They compare, contrast and analyse the news they view, assessing the fairness and accuracy of each channel using other sources as well as their pre-existing belief frameworks.

In our sample, most viewers over 10 years of age, from all communities, expressed the opinion that the television channels available to them are manipulated by dominant political interests, usually British or American ones. A strong sense was expressed that it is important and informative to watch channels broadcast by one's 'enemies' or by those political conglomerates one distrusts most. In India, Hindu viewers wanted to watch Al-Jazeera and PTV 'to see what they were saying', just as some of the British-Bangladeshi youth watched CNN mainly to see what the Americans were saying.

For almost every member of our sample, news viewing was a deeply and constantly political activity. As interviewers, we attempted to steer questions away from any notion of direct effects, but interviewees repeatedly dwelt on effects, prompting us to ask them about the ways in which news viewing after September 11 may have altered their opinions and beliefs. Examined side-by-side, the two views—namely that news organisations are not autonomous, and that viewers are influenced by news broadcasts—amount to a belief, on the part of at least some interviewees, in the inextricably political nature of the act of viewing news. Nevertheless viewers in our sample return both to channels that they like and generally trust, and to those they are frustrated by and do not trust, for a range of complex reasons. They do so, increasingly, without the expectation that television channels will provide them with impartial, conclusive and definitive 'news' about their locality, nation, region or the world. One viewer, asked to explain why he prefers to experience a wide variety of media texts—websites, newspapers and news channels from different countries and regions—rather than depend on one or two supposedly 'neutral' news sources, told us: 'Neutrality comes from within me, so I think *I* would like to form the basis of neutrality'. This opinion reflects an understanding of the partiality of all perspectives on world events, whether those of individuals, governments or news corporations, and indicates the extent to which some multilingual South-Asian news viewers have taken on the responsibility of being 'active' constructors of their own 'jigsaws of truth'.

Notes

[1] We use the term 'South-Asian' to describe interviewees where this was generally how they described themselves at some point during our interviews. The term Indian is used in the title to refer to interviewees in India as the term British-Asian is used to refer to interviewees of South-Asian origin in the UK. Other terms of self-definition used were 'Indian', 'British-Pakistani', 'British-Asian', 'British-Bangladeshi', 'Hindu', 'Muslim' and 'Sikh'.

[2] On 24 December 1999, Indian Airlines Airbus 300, coming from Kathmandu, Nepal, was hijacked and taken to Kandahar, Afghanistan.

References

Anand, J. and Setalwad, T. (eds) (2002) *Genocide: Gujarat*. Bombay: Special report, *Communalism Combat*, 77–8: March–April.

Barker, C. (1999) *Television, Globalisation and Cultural Identities*. Buckingham and Philadelphia: Open University Press.

Barker, C. and Galasinski, D. (2002) *Cultural Studies and Discourse Analysis*. London: Thousand Oaks; New Delhi: Sage.

Bharucha, R. (1998) *In the Name of the Secular*. Delhi: Oxford University Press.

Bharucha, R. (2001) *The Politics of Cultural Practice*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.

Boyd-Barrett, O. (1997) 'Global news wholesalers as agents of globalisation', in Srebreny-Mohamaddi, A., Winseck, D., McKenna, J. and Boyd-Barrett, O. (eds) *Media in a Global Context*. London: Arnold, 131–44.

Byerly, C.M. (1997) 'News, consciousness and social participation: the role of women's feature service in world news', in Srebreny-Mohamaddi, A., Winseck, D., McKenna, J. and Boyd-Barrett, O. (eds) *Media in a Global Context*. London: Arnold, 248–58.

Curran, J. and Seaton, J. (2000) *Power Without Responsibility: The Press and Broadcasting in Britain*. London and New York: Routledge.

Fiske, J. (1987) *Television Culture*. London and New York: Methuen.

Fontana, A. and Frey, J. (1998) 'Interviewing: the art of science', in Denzin, N. and Lincoln, Y. (eds) *Collecting and Interpreting Qualitative Materials*. London: Sage, 47–78.

Hansen, T.B. (1999) *The Saffron Wave: Hindu Nationalism and Democracy in Modern India. Princeton*. NJ: Princeton University Press.

Hensman, R. (1995) 'Fascism, democratic rights and the state', *Economic and Political Weekly*, 27 May, 1262.

Narula, S. (2002) '"We have no orders to save you": state participation and complicity in communal violence in Gujarat', *Human Rights Watch Report*, *14* (3).

Kellner, D. (2003a) 'September 11, spectacles of terror, and media manipulation: a critique of Jihadist and Bush media politics', *Logos, 2*(1): 86–102.

Kellner, D. (2003b) *Media Spectacle*. London and New York: Routledge.

Mankekar, P. (2000) *Screening Culture, Viewing Politics: Television, Womanhood and Nation in Modern India*. New Delhi and Bombay: Oxford University Press.

Paterson, C. (1997) 'Global television news services', in Srebreny-Mohamaddi, A., Winseck, D., McKenna, J. and Boyd-Barrett, O. (eds) *Media in a Global Context*. London: Arnold, 145–60.

Rajagopal, A. (2001) *Politics After Television: Hindu Nationalism and the Reshaping of the Public in India*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

Sarkar, S. (1993) 'The Fascism of the Sangh Parivar', *Economic and Political Weekly*, 30 January, 163–8.

Sarkar, T. (2002) 'Semiotics of terror', *Economic and Political Weekly, 37*(28): 2872–6.